Welcome to the Galaxy: A Beginner's Overview

This introductory guide is designed to help new Commanders find their footing in the Milky Way. It breaks down the basic paths to earning your first credits, getting your first ship unlocks, navigating third-party platforms, and seeing the sights without getting overwhelmed by complex end-game math.

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1. The Golden Rule: Connecting to INARA

Before doing anything else, every beginner should link their game to **INARA.cz**. Elite Dangerous does not show real-time market values, station item stocks, or progression bars clearly in the main menu. This tool fixes that.

How to set up Real-Time Sync (Recommended)

You can use a tiny background application called **EDMC (Elite Dangerous Market Connector)** to automatically update your web profile while you play.

- **Step 1:** Go to INARA.cz and sign up for a free account.
- **Step 2:** Click your name, go to *Commander Settings*, find the *API Key* tab, and generate a code. Copy it safely.
- **Step 3:** Download and install EDMC from GitHub.
- **Step 4:** Open EDMC's settings, click the *Inara* tab, check the box to send your flight logs, and paste your API key.

- **Step 5:** Play the game! The application will run quietly in the background and instantly display your credit balance, current system, and materials inventory on the website.

2. Simple Starter Credit Methods

Early-Game: Space Police Bounty Hunting

The Goal: Earn millions safely in your starter ship without risking your own credits.

The Method: Fly to a planet with rings and drop into a **Resource Extraction Site [Low]**. Do not pick a fight alone. Instead, follow the local System Authority police ships around. Wait for them to attack a pirate. When the pirate's health falls below **10%**, fire your lasers to land a few hits. You will receive 100% of the credit bounty when they explode.

First Upgrade: Save up for a **Cobra Mk III** — the best starter all-rounder ship in the game.

Video Guide: Search 'Elite Dangerous Bounty Hunting Tutorial' on YouTube.

Mid-Game: The Robigo Passenger Run

The Goal: Consistent, low-risk millions once you buy a medium cargo ship.

The Method: Buy a **Python**, travel to station **Robigo Mines** in the **Robigo** system, and fill it with passenger cabins. Take sightseeing missions heading directly to the **Sirius Atmospheric Beacon** in the nearby **Sothis** system. Make sure your ship has a jump range of at least **30.15 Light Years** so you can make the trip back and forth in just two rapid jumps.

Video Guide: Search 'Robigo Mines Passenger Guide' on YouTube.

3. Intro to Exobiology & The Spansh Shortcut

Exobiology (scanning alien plants) requires the **Odyssey Expansion** but is currently the most profitable activity for a brand-new player.

The Planetary Exploration Loop

Buy an **Artemis Suit** from any station weapon shop. Equip your ship with a **Detailed Surface Scanner (DSS)**. Fly to a planet, shoot your scanner probes at it until it is mapped, and look at the blue organic overlay map to see where plants are growing. Land your ship, walk up to a plant, and click your genetic sampler tool to log it.

The Clonal Diversity Rule

Your sampler requires **three separate plant logs** to complete a data set. You cannot just scan the exact same patch of grass. You must travel a short physical distance away before the scanner accepts the next sample:

- **Bacteria / Tussock:** Move **200+ meters** away between scans.
- **Aleoida:** Move **500+ meters** away between scans.
- **Stratum:** Move **100–200 meters** away between scans.

Using Spansh.co.uk for Easy Paths

Don't wander the galaxy blindly looking for plants. Open the website **Spansh Expressway to Exomastery**. Input your starting star system and your ship's jump range. Set your *Max Arrival Distance* to **2,000 ls** (so you don't have to cruise through space for a half hour). Set the *Minimum Value* filter to **10,000,000 credits**. The tool will calculate a direct roadmap of planets holding high-value targets like **Stratum Tectonicas**, which give you a massive **95 Million Credit payout** if you are the first person to log them.

Video Guide: Search 'Elite Dangerous Spansh Exobiology Guide' on YouTube.

4. Understanding Powerplay 2.0 Basics

Powerplay is an optional, galaxy-wide political strategy game where you pledge your allegiance to one of **12 Major Factions** to earn ranks, credits, and unique modules.

Common System Meanings

- **Acquisition / Expansion:** Factions are currently fighting to take control of this territory.
- **Contested:** A chaotic warzone where rival powers are actively clashing.
- **Fortified / Reinforced:** Safe, secure strongholds acting as defensive anchors for a faction.

Easy Ways to Earn Merits

You progress with your chosen leader by earning **Merits**. Unlike old versions of the game, your progress does not cut in half every week, making it much friendlier for beginners.

- **Trading:** Deliver specific rare trade commodities from your faction’s home stations to the systems they are trying to conquer.
- **Combat:** Fly into conflict zones or Resource Extraction Sites in systems your faction controls and hunt down rival pirate targets.
- **Hacking:** Fly to a rival faction's space station, target the holographic transmission billboard towers floating outside, and use a *Recon Limpet* module to steal data logs for an easy **21 Merits per hack**.

5. Unlocking Your First Faction Ships

Some of the most iconic large ships in the game require you to earn a naval rank with either the Federation or the Empire before you can purchase them.

The Federal Corvette Path: Fly to the sister systems of **Ceos** and **Sothis**. Take as many simple *Data Courier Missions* as you can hold between the two systems. Always pick the **Reputation (Rep+++++)** option when completing missions to hit Rank 12 (Rear Admiral) quickly.

The Imperial Cutter Path: Travel to systems **Ngalinn** and **Mainani**. Bring a small or medium landing-pad ship and loop data courier delivery missions back and forth between them while picking **Reputation** rewards until you reach Rank 12 (Duke).

6. Beginner Engineering & Guardian Basics

Engineering lets you upgrade your ship's modules to jump further, shoot harder, and fly faster.

The First Three Vital Engineers

- **Felicity Farseer (System: Deciat):** The absolute most important engineer for beginners. She upgrades your Frame Shift Drive so your ship can jump much further. *Requires you to bring her 1 unit of Meta-Alloy to unlock her workshop.*
- **The Dweller (System: Wyrd):** Upgrades your power distributors so your lasers can fire longer. *Requires making 5 quick transactions at any black market.*
- **Professor Palin (System: Arque):** Upgrades your engines so your ship can boost away from danger with maximum speed.

The Guardian FSD Booster (Flat +10.5 LY Jump Bonus)

This alien component is a must-have item that instantly adds up to 10.5 Light Years of jump distance to any ship you put it in.

- Fly a small explorer ship out to the alien ruins in system **Synuefe IL-N c23-19**.
- Put a **Point Defense Turret** on the top slot of your ship — it will automatically shoot down alien missiles while you are on the ground.
- Drive your SRV ground car around the ruins, shoot the 6 glowing pylon towers to power up the site, drop an Ancient Relic into the floor slot, and scan the floating blue energy orb to download your blueprint.

7. The 2026 New Pilot Briefing

- **The New Rigs:** The **Kestrel Mk II** is a small, heavy-hitting fighter variant; the **Faulcon DeLacy Nomad** is an exploration ship featuring a fully walkable interior room; and the **Python Mk II** is a specialized shield-heavy combat ship built to use Supercruise Overcharge modules smoothly.
- **Co-Op Boarding Ops:** High-tier team missions where squads board enemy megaships to fight computer targets and earn a custom currency called **Merc Coins**.
- **System Colonization:** An end-game system where rich players pay 25 Million credits to claim an empty star system, then haul thousands of tons of cargo to build their own custom space outpost.

8. Easy Sightseeing Destinations

Location	Star System	Why You Should Visit	Distance
Mitterand Hollow	Epsilon Indi	A chaotic 'glitch moon' that orbits its gas giant every 90 seconds, causing rapid horizons.	Inside Bubble
Gen Ship Thetis	Neitha	An abandoned ghost ship floating in space. Scan its logs to hear an eerie story.	Inside Bubble
Thargoid Structure	Delphi	A massive, active alien biomechanical base built right onto a planet surface.	~350 LY away
Crystal Shard Forests	HIP 36601	Tall glowing spires that drop top-grade raw engineering materials when shot.	~1,500 LY away
Collection of Wonders	Skaude AL-X e2-530	A stunning point where two black holes, a neutron star, and ringed stars intersect.	~11,000 LY away

9. The Essential Bookmark List

- **INARA.cz:** Your main hub. Use it to find out where to sell cargo for the highest prices, where to buy specific ships, and where to track your ranks.
- **Spansh.co.uk:** The ultimate route calculator. Essential for plotting multi-million credit exobiology paths and neutron star jump networks.
- **Coriolis.io:** A virtual garage sandbox. Use it to build out potential ship setups and check how much they cost before buying them in-game.
- **EDMC Tool:** The light background tool that auto-syncs your active game logs to your web browsers.

10. Important Galactic Disclaimer

*Elite Dangerous features a **constantly fluctuating, player-driven economy**. Market trading demands, faction states, mineral buy rates, and system populations shift regularly. What is highly profitable on INARA today may experience a structural supply crash tomorrow.*

*Furthermore, this handbook maps out a few highly optimized beginner paths, but **there is no single right way to play Elite Dangerous**. The galaxy accommodates pilots who ignore credit metas completely to focus on raw exploration, asymmetric deep-space piracy, fuel rat rescue coordination, or casual trucking. Use these loops to build up your baseline capital, but prioritize whatever career brings you the most fulfillment out in the black. Fly safe, Commander!*